Setting up a Collect Earth Cloud project: the coordinator's manual

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This manual takes a coordinator from nothing to a running Collect Earth Cloud project: the survey on the server, plots given out, interpreters invited and working, quality checks on. Plan about an hour for the set-up, most of it preparing the files.

Before you start

What you need

	What	Where it comes from
1	The **server's address**	The shared server of the Collect Earth team, or your organisation's own server (see the guide *Collect Earth data collection: four ways to set it up*)
2	An **account** that may create projects	Sign up on the server, or ask its administrator
3	The **project file** (`.cep`) of the survey, tested	Collect Earth's survey designer. Open it in Collect Earth on your own computer first and assess a few plots, to be sure the form works
4	The **plot files** (`.csv`)	One row per plot: plot id, latitude, longitude, then the extra columns the survey reads
5	The **list of people** and their roles	Who interprets (collectors), who helps check (reviewers), who co-coordinates
6	Your **quality plan**	How many plots each person should have checked by someone else, and whether you use reference plots or training

The order of the steps

1. Create the project.
2. Upload the project file.
3. Upload the plot files.

4. Invite the people.
5. Give out the plots (whole files or divided).
6. Switch on the quality checks and, if wanted, training.
7. Set the progress settings, emails and links.
8. Follow the work.

Steps 2 and 3 should be final before people start: the project file can still be replaced later, but people who already joined must then fetch it again (Step 2 explains how).

Words used in this manual

- **Coordinator, reviewer, collector**: the three roles in a project (Step 4).
- **Interpreter**: anyone who assesses plots in Collect Earth, usually a collector.
- **Submitted**: a plot whose interpreter pressed **Submit**. Saved but not submitted plots count as *started*.
- **Check**: a second, blind assessment of a plot by another person, to measure agreement.

Step 1: your account and the project

Get an account

Open the server's address in a web browser. Depending on how the server is set up:

- **Sign-up is open** (the shared server): press **Sign up**, choose a username (3 to 64 letters, digits or `. _ - @`) and a password of at least 8 characters, and accept the terms of use if the server has them.
- **Sign-up is closed** (most private servers): the server's administrator invites you, or makes you a project. An invitation link as *coordinator* gives you an account and the project at once.

Add an email address on your **Account** page if the server sends email: it lets you reset a forgotten password yourself and receive the weekly summary.

Create the project

1. Go to **My projects → New project**.
2. Type the project's name: everyone in the project sees it, so make it clear ("Mozambique forest inventory 2026 – Sofala"). It can be changed later in **Settings**.
3. Press **Create the project**. You are its coordinator.

If the server refuses, it says why: only its administrators may create projects, or you already coordinate as many projects as one person may.

The setup checklist

The new project opens on a checklist of five steps, each with a button to the right tab. A step ticks itself once it is done:

Step	Done when	Tab
Upload the project file	A `.cep` is on the server	Project file
Add plot files	At least one plot file is uploaded	Plot files
Invite people	Someone else is in the project, or an invitation link is open	People
Choose who collects each plot file	At least one file is given to someone	Plot files
Follow the progress	The first plot has arrived	Data

The rest of this manual follows the same order, with the details and the options the checklist does not show.

Other coordinators

A project can have several coordinators, who all see and change everything. Invite them with a link whose role is *Coordinator* (Step 4), or change someone's role on the **People** tab. The last coordinator of a project cannot be removed or demoted.

Step 2: the project file

Prepare it

- **Test it locally first.** Open the `.cep` in Collect Earth on your computer (**File → Import CEP file**), assess and submit two or three plots, and export them. Mistakes in the form are much harder to fix once people are working.
- **Keep the plot `id` as the survey's only key** if you can. The server can then add the hidden `round` key that makes quality checks blind and keeps a check from overwriting the first assessment.

- **Keep the files the survey designer made** (`balloon.html` , `kml_template.fmt`) as they are: the server looks for markers in them when it adds `round` and the coordinator's comment field.
- **Leave out large extras** (videos, many images): every member downloads the file.

Upload it

1. Open the **Project file** tab.
2. Drag the `.cep` onto the page, or press **Choose the .cep file**.
3. Read what the page says under **Assessment round**:

The page says	Meaning	What to do
We added a hidden 'round' to the survey so that quality checks are blind	The survey's only key was the plot id; collectors get the version with `round`	Nothing. **Download the file you uploaded** still gives your original
Your survey already has 'round'	You built `round` in yourself	Choose **Which code marks a re-assessment?**, or *None* when `round` means something else (a year)
The server did not add 'round' because…	The survey has several keys, several main entities, a non-key question called `round` , or a missing form or template marker	Either fix the survey in the designer and upload again, or carry on: the dashboard still tells first assessments and checks apart, from who held each plot as a check copy
Your survey has no 'round'. Data had already been collected…	The file came after the first plots	Carry on, as above

The page also says whether **coordinators' comments** will show at the top of a plot's form in Collect Earth when you send a plot back for another look.

Replacing it later

You can upload a new version at any time with **Choose a new version**. The server refuses a version that would no longer match the plots already collected (different keys, `round` removed, a round code removed, plots read differently), and says which.

People who already joined keep the old version. Collect Earth downloads the project file only when joining. For each of them:

1. Open their page (**People** tab, click the name). It says *Has an old project file* when they need the new one.
2. Press **Make a link for the new project file** and send it to that person only. It is shown once.
3. In Collect Earth they choose **File → Join cloud project…**, paste the link, and press **Log in** with their own account (not *Register*). Collect Earth downloads the current project file and restarts. Their role and their plots stay as they were.

Ask people to submit or at least sync their work before switching, and avoid changing questions mid-project: records saved with the old form keep their old answers.

Step 3: plot files, and who collects them

The file format

The same CSV files Collect Earth opens locally:

```
id,lat,lon,elevation,province
1001,-19.84,34.86,12,Sofala
1002,-19.85,34.87,15,Sofala
```

- **Column 1:** the plot id. It must fit the survey: numbers if the survey's id is a number.
- **Columns 2 and 3:** latitude and longitude (or the coordinates of the survey's reference system).
- **Then** the extra columns the survey reads from the plot file, in its order.
- One plot per row. Comma, semicolon or tab separated, with or without a header row.

Split very large inventories into several files (by province, by batch): each file can be given out and followed on its own.

Upload

1. **Plot files** tab → drag in the files, or **Choose CSV files**. Several at once are fine.
2. Read the line under each file: the number of plots, and any warning (repeated plot ids, rows without coordinates, ids the survey cannot take). Fix the file and upload it again with **the same name**: it replaces the old one.
3. Replacing a file that leaves plots out asks first, showing how many of those plots are given to people and how many have submitted records. Records already submitted are kept but counted as *in no plot file*.

Give each file out: two ways

	Whole file	Divided
Each person gets	All plots of the file	Only their share
Use it when	One person per file, or a small file everyone does	A team shares one file
Quality checks possible	No (blind checks and reference plots need divided files)	Yes
Set it on	The **Who collects each file** table	The file's **Divide plots** page

Whole file. In the table, tick a box for each person who collects each file, then **Save**. People need to have joined first: until then the table says *Invite people first*.

Divided. Press **Divide plots** on the file:

1. **How to divide**: *Evenly between people* (about the same number each), or *By a column* (choose a column such as province, then who collects each value; *Give every value to one person, in turn* fills it in for you). Columns with more than 200 different values cannot be used.
2. **Who collects**: tick the people.
3. **Which plots go together**: *In the order of the file*, *Mix them* (plots from all over the file), or *Keep plots that are close on the map together* (each person gets one area, and Collect Earth orders their plots so each next plot is mostly nearby).
4. **Quality check** (optional): *Also give some plots to a second person, to compare answers*, with the share of each person's plots, 5 to 50 %. Those copies are blind.
5. **Preview** shows what each person would get. **Apply** saves it.

Dividing again never loses work: plots someone already submitted stay with that person whenever they are among the people chosen.

When someone stops or falls behind

On the divided file's page, next to each person, **Move unfinished plots to…** gives everything they have not submitted to someone else. What they submitted stays with them; a plot the other person already assessed or checked also stays, so nobody assesses a plot twice.

What the interpreters do

In Collect Earth they open **Settings**, choose the file in **Assigned plot file**, and apply. When you change a division or give them a new file, **Refresh assignments** there fetches the new list. Tell them when you do.

Step 4: people

The three roles

Role	For	Sees on the dashboard	Can change
Collector	Interpreters	**My work**: their own plots, their own quality figures, their training	Nothing but their own account
Reviewer	People who help check quality, often senior interpreters	Progress, Map, plot pages, plots worth a look, calibration figures without names	Nothing in the project's set-up
Coordinator	People who run the project	Everything, including names, quality and time spent per person	Everything

Reviewers and coordinators can also collect plots. Their own quality checks cannot be blind, though: they can read first assessments on the dashboard. Give automatic checks to collectors.

Make an invitation link

On the **People** tab, under **Invite people**:

1. **They join as**: Collector, Reviewer or Coordinator.
2. **How many people can use it**: 1 for one person, or more (up to 10,000) for a whole team or a training room.
3. **The link works for**: 1 day, 1 week, 1 month, or no time limit.
4. Press **Make the invitation link**, and **copy it now**: for safety it is shown only once.
5. Send it by email or chat.

Open links are listed under **Invitation links still open**, with how many times each was used. **Stop this link** ends it at once; people who already joined stay.

What the people you invite do

The link opens a page that explains it, in their language:

1. Install Collect Earth (Windows, Mac or Linux), if they do not have it.
2. Open Collect Earth and choose **File → Join cloud project…**.
3. Paste the invitation link. Collect Earth shows the project's name and the role.
4. Choose a username and a password (or log in with an existing account on the same server).
5. Collect Earth downloads the project file, switches to the cloud project and restarts.
6. In **Settings**, they choose their file in **Assigned plot file** (after Step 3).

The page also tells them what coordinators and reviewers can see of their work.

Managing people

Under **People in this project**:

- **Change a role** with the menu next to the name.
- **Remove someone**: they can no longer send plots to the project; what they already sent is kept.
- **Click a name** for their page: their plots, calendar, speed, time spent per plot, sync, quality, and **Make a link for the new project file** when they have an old one.

Forgotten passwords: with email on the server, they use **Forgot your password?** themselves; otherwise the server's administrator makes a reset link.

Step 5: quality checks and training

All of these are optional, and all live on the **Quality** and **Training** tabs. They work only with **divided** plot files: a file given whole cannot hold checks or reference plots.

Three ways to measure quality

	Overlap when dividing	Automatic checks	Reference plots
What it is	A share of each person's plots also goes to a second person	Submitted plots are drawn for a second, blind assessment	An expert assesses some plots; every collector also does them blind
Measures	Agreement between two people	Agreement between two people	Accuracy against the expert

	Overlap when dividing	Automatic checks	Reference plots
Set on	**Divide plots** (5 to 50 %)	**Quality → Automatic checks**	**Quality → Reference plots**
Best for	A fixed share, decided at the start	Checking early work closely, and a steady share after	Training needs, and a fair comparison between people

Automatic checks

1. **Check the first plots each person submits**: how many (catches a misunderstanding early), and/or
2. **Check a share of each person's plots** (%): spread over the weeks.
3. **Who may receive checks**: every collector, or only those ticked. Reviewers and coordinators are warned that their checks may not be blind.
4. Per plot file: *As above*, *No checks*, or *A rule of its own*.
5. **Save**. Plots submitted from now on are drawn automatically. **Draw now** also draws among plots already submitted.

Each plot drawn goes, as a copy, to someone who has not assessed it and has the fewest checks to do. It arrives in their plot file after **Refresh assignments**, like any other plot.

Reference plots

1. Choose a divided plot file and a **reference assessor** (a coordinator or a reviewer).
2. Pick plots **at random among the plots nobody has started**, or type their ids.
3. **Mark as reference plots**. The assessor gets them as their own; every collector gets a copy, blind. Up to 500 per project.
4. Accuracy per person and per question appears once the reference assessments are submitted.

How answers are compared

- **Margins for numbers** (Quality tab): two numbers agree when they differ by no more than this share of the larger one. With 10 %, 100 and 90 agree.
- **Very fast**: a plot submitted within this many seconds of the person's previous one is listed under *plots worth a look* (default 15 seconds, 1 to 120).
- **Time spent on each plot** needs no setting: Collect Earth counts each plot's active time, and plots done in under a quarter of the team's usual time are listed on the People tab.

- **Guidance notes**: when a question is often answered differently, write a note ("When crowns cover less than 10 %, choose Grassland"). People see the notes about their own mix-ups on **My work**.

Training sets

On the **Training** tab, before or alongside the real work:

- **Calibration**: several people assess the same plots; the dashboard shows how much they agree, question by question, and proposes the agreed answer for each.
- **Learning plots**: plots with a golden (agreed) answer. Right after submitting each plot, the trainee sees their answers next to the golden ones, with your explanation. Each attempt is scored, with an optional pass mark.

Upload the training plot file on the Training tab (not on Plot files), choose the participants, and they get it in Collect Earth like any plot file. Training plots never mix with the project's data.

Step 6: progress settings, emails, links and the AI assistant

Progress settings (Settings tab)

Setting	What it does	Default
Deadline	The last day of the collection; the Progress tab forecasts whether it will be met	None
Target in plots	The number of plots to finish; empty counts every plot given to someone	None
Quiet after this many days	Someone with plots left who has neither synced nor downloaded plots for longer shows as quiet	3 days (1 to 365)

Weekly emails (your Account page)

When the server sends email, each person chooses their own, sent on Mondays about the week before:

- **Weekly summary of the projects I coordinate**: plots done that week and in all, who has gone quiet, plots waiting for your decision.
- **My week** (for interpreters): their own plots submitted and left, and plots sent back to them.

They need a confirmed email address on the account. Tell your team to add one.

Progress links for funders (Settings tab)

Make a link gives a page that opens without logging in. It shows the project's name, how many plots are done, the progress chart, the forecast and the agreement as one figure. It never shows names, answers, plot ids or where the plots are. Add a note to tell links apart ("For the donor"); copy the link at once, as it is shown only once. **Revoke** stops it.

AI assistant (Settings tab)

Where the server allows it, **Use the AI assistant in this project** lets an assistant on the Quality tab review the quality figures and suggest guidance notes and plots to check again. It never changes anything. What it is sent: answers to choice and number questions, the survey's questions and help texts, and your notes, with names replaced by *Person A*, *Person B*. Coordinates, comments and other text answers are never sent. It stays off until a coordinator switches it on.

Error reports and usage counts

These are a server setting, not a project one. A private server sends nothing unless its administrator switches it on; nothing personal is ever sent.

Running the project

The first days

- Watch the **People** tab: each person should show a first sync and a first plot within a day of joining. *Never* under last sync means Collect Earth has not reached the server: help them before they work offline for days.
- Open a few of each person's first plots (**Map** or **Plots** search → the plot's page) and look at the answers.
- If you switched on *Check the first plots each person submits*, the first checks arrive within days: read the **Quality** tab's disagreements early, while misunderstandings are cheap to fix.

Every week

Where	What to look at	What to do
Progress	Plots done per day, the forecast against the deadline, the attention cards	Move unfinished plots from someone who is behind or quiet
People	Last sync, plots left, agreement, time spent per plot and quick plots	Talk to people with many quick plots or low agreement
Quality	Agreement by question and by person, the most confused answers, *plots worth a look*	Write guidance notes; decide plots where answers differ
Quality → review queue	Plots waiting for a decision	Choose which answer is right, or send the plot back for another look with a comment
Activity	What happened, and when	Check that nothing unexpected changed

Deciding a plot

When a first assessment and a check differ, the plot waits for your decision:

- **The first answer is right**, or **the check is right**: that answer becomes the plot's final answer in the downloads.
- **Both need another look**: the plot goes back to both people, with your comment at the top of its form in Collect Earth.

Downloads and backups (Data tab)

- **CSV**: one row per record, with the columns `plot`, `round`, `assessment` (main, check or other) and `final` (the answer you chose), then every answer. Open it in a spreadsheet or R.
- **Collect backup**: the records as Open Foris Collect and Collect Earth read them, to open the data in those programs.

Download both regularly and keep them outside the server, even though the server is backed up.

Closing the project

1. Check the **Progress** tab says every plot is submitted, and the review queue is empty.

2. Download the CSV and the Collect backup, and keep them safely.
3. Stop open invitation links and progress links.
4. Either leave the project as an archive, or delete it on the **Settings** tab (type its name to confirm). Deleting removes the project file, the plot files, the links and every plot collected, and cannot be undone.

Checklist and troubleshooting

Before people start

- [ ] The `.cep` was tested in Collect Earth locally, and plots submitted and exported
- [ ] The project file is uploaded, and the **Assessment round** box read
- [ ] Every plot file is uploaded with no warnings left
- [ ] Each file is given whole or divided, and the preview checked
- [ ] Quality checks set (overlap, automatic checks or reference plots), if wanted
- [ ] Margins for number questions set
- [ ] Deadline, target and quiet days set
- [ ] Invitation links made with the right roles, and sent
- [ ] Everyone joined, chose their assigned plot file and shows a first sync

When something goes wrong

What you see	Likely cause	What to do
Someone never shows a sync	They did not join with **File → Join cloud project…**, they are offline, or they are not logged in	Ask them to open **Cloud sync status…** in Collect Earth and send you what it says
The cloud server assigns you no plot file in this project yet (in Collect Earth)	Nothing is given to them, or they have no plots in a divided file	Give them a file or a share, then they press **Refresh assignments**
Someone has plots they should not have	An old division, or a file given whole by mistake	Untick them in the table, or divide again; they press **Refresh assignments**
Has an old project file on someone's page	You replaced the project file after they joined	**Make a link for the new project file** and send it

What you see	Likely cause	What to do
An upload of the project file is refused	It would no longer match plots already collected	Read the message; keep the same keys and the `round` codes
Plot file warnings about ids or coordinates	Mistakes in the CSV	Fix the CSV and upload it again with the same name
No quality figures	No plot has both a first assessment and a check yet, or fewer than 20 checks	Wait, or draw checks now on **Quality → Automatic checks**
A plot appears *in no plot file*	Its plot was removed when a file was replaced	Put the plot back in a file, or accept that it is left out
The link a person received does not work	It expired, was stopped, or was used up	Make a new one

Where to read more

- *How the survey reaches the interpreters in a cloud project*: what travels where, step by step.
- *Collect Earth data collection: four ways to set it up*: choosing between local and cloud collection, and installing your own server.